

Odobenus rosmarus

Walrus



Location Arctic waters

Length 8¼–11¼ ft (2.5–3.5 m)
Weight 1,760–3,970 lb (800–1,800 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Data deficient



The male walrus is twice the weight of the female. Both sexes have tusks, which are used for support when foraging on the sea floor, and help anchor them to the edges of ice floes. The walrus's blunt, thickly whiskered muzzle widens rapidly to the head, neck, and chest, then tapers markedly to the tail, which is embedded in a web of skin. It feeds mainly on seabed dwelling worms, shellfish, sea snails, shrimps, and slow-moving fish. The

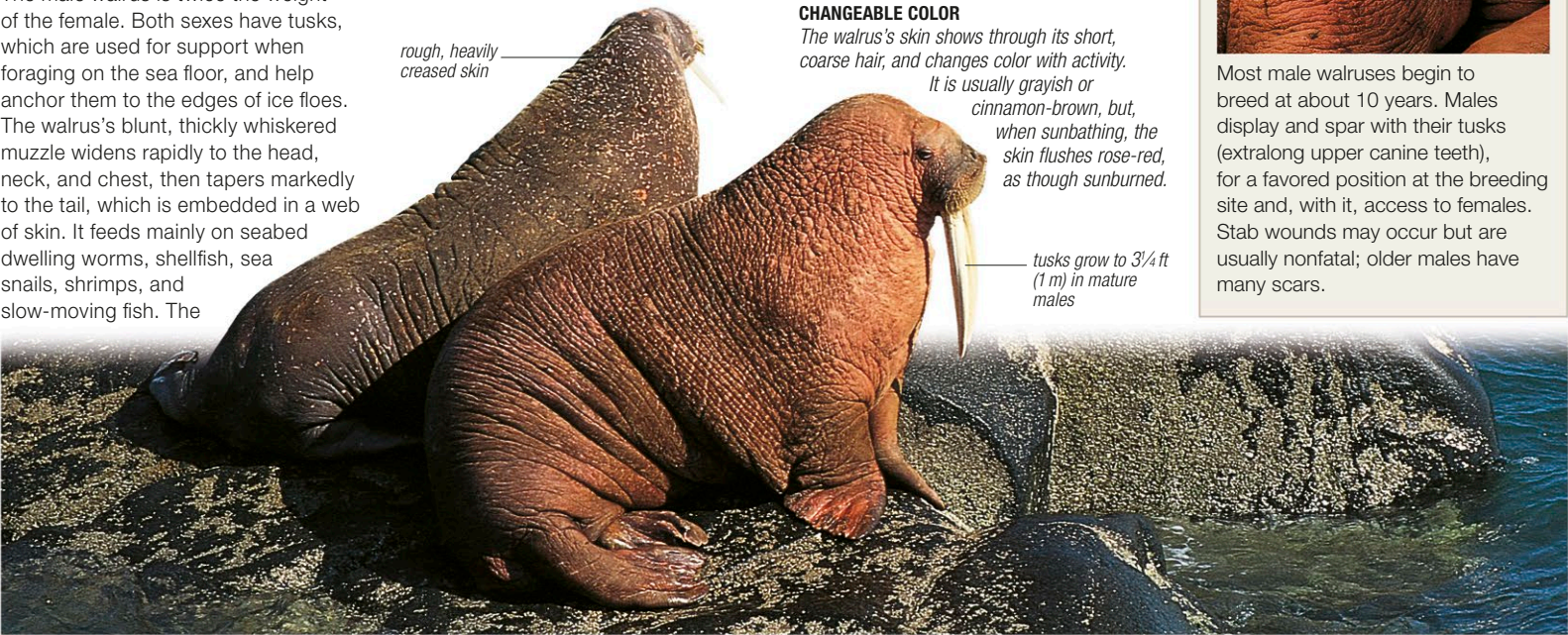
walrus dives more than 330 ft (100 m) deep, for 25 minutes or more, to find prey using the touch of its whiskers and snout. It then excavates the food with its nose, aided by jets of water squirted from its mouth. Items are eaten mainly by suction with the mouth and tongue, rather than using the teeth. Walruses are social and huddle on land or ice floes in large, mixed groups of hundreds, which split at sea into smaller bands of less than 10; bachelor males tend to form

their own gatherings. Courting males make underwater pulses and bellows to attract partners, and mating occurs between January and March. The pup, born after 15 months (which includes 4–5 months' delayed implantation), is up to 4 ft (1.2 m) long and 165 lb (75 kg) in weight. It suckles for 6 months and is weaned over the following 18 months. Mothers are extremely protective of their young, and other females may "adopt" pups that have been orphaned.

CHANGEABLE COLOR
The walrus's skin shows through its short, coarse hair, and changes color with activity. It is usually grayish or cinnamon-brown, but, when sunbathing, the skin flushes rose-red, as though sunburned.

tusks grow to 3¼ ft (1 m) in mature males

rough, heavily creased skin



SPARRING RIVALS



Most male walruses begin to breed at about 10 years. Males display and spar with their tusks (extralong upper canine teeth), for a favored position at the breeding site and, with it, access to females. Stab wounds may occur but are usually nonfatal; older males have many scars.

Monachus monachus

Mediterranean monk seal



Location Mediterranean, Atlantic (N.W. Africa)

Length 7½–9¼ ft (2.3–2.8 m)
Weight 530–660 lb (240–300 kg)
Social unit Individual/Group
Status Critically endangered



This species has smooth, dark brown fur, paler beneath, and eats mainly fish, such as eels, sardines, and tuna, as well as lobster and octopus. On land, it is less social than most other seals, with the mother-pup pairs or small groups being widely spaced. This extremely rare species is sensitive to human disturbance such as tourism, so hides in sea caves. Cave collapses, pollution, overfishing, and viral infection are also serious threats.

Lobodon carcinophaga

Crabeater seal



Location Antarctic and subantarctic waters

Length 7½–7¾ ft (2.3–2.4 m)
Weight 435–450 lb (198–207 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern



The long, lithe crabeater seal has oar-shaped, pointed front flippers and a silver-gray to yellow-brown coat with irregular darker spots and rings. One of the most abundant and fastest seals, it swims at 16 mph (25 kph). A typical feeding dive is down to 130 ft (40 m) for 5 minutes. Despite its name, the crabeater seal strains krill using its unusual lobed teeth. Breeding habits are typical for seals, although the male stays with female and pup until weaning takes place at 3 weeks.



Hydrurga leptonyx

Leopard seal



Location Antarctic and subantarctic waters

Length 7¾–11¼ ft (2.4–3.4 m)
Weight 440–1,000 lb (200–455 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



silver or gray coat with variable dark spots

The solitary, sinuous leopard seal is widest at the shoulders and, unusually for a true seal (phocid), swims with its front flippers, which have claws on the fingertips. The head is reptile-like in proportions, with no forehead and a wide, deep lower jaw. The 1-in (2.5-cm) canine teeth are adapted for seizing smaller seals, penguins, and other birds; the diet also includes squid and krill.

Leptonychotes weddellii

Weddell seal



Location Antarctic and subantarctic waters

Length 9½–10¼ ft (2.8–3.3 m)
Weight 880–1,320 lb (400–600 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern



Bulky, but small-headed and short-flipper, the Weddell seal has a short, blunt muzzle and few, short whiskers. To find fish, squid, and other prey, it dives

to depths of 1,600 ft (500 m) for one hour. This seal bites breathing holes in sheet ice with its long, upper incisor teeth.



silver-gray back